

Course Overview

14.33 Research and Communication in Economics

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Today's plan

- Introductions
- Syllabus review, discussion, and feedback
- Overview of developing a research topic
- Case study of two published papers

Introductions

- Name
- Year
- Course #
- One fun thing you did this summer

Syllabus review

- Read and reflect individually (20 minutes)
- Debrief discussion and Q&A

Your feedback

Based on the syllabus, write on an index card:

- What would you like to **stop** happening in the course?
- What would you like to **start** happening in the course?
- What would you like to **continue** happening in the course?

Developing a research topic

- **Research question:** what you want to learn
- **Setting:** institutional context relevant to answering the question
- **Data:** empirical measurements relevant to answering the question

Research question

- Specific enough to answer empirically
- Motivated by an economic theory or a substantive policy issue
- May concern a **causal** effect or a **descriptive** relationship

Setting

- Institutional details relevant to answering the question
- **Causal**: variation supporting a credible comparison to an unobserved counterfactual
- **Descriptive**: a context in which theory has testable predictions

Data

- Quantifiable measures relevant to answering the question
- May be numeric or constructed from text, images, and other records

Initial ideas

3 minutes, individually

- Write one economic theory or policy issue that interests you.
- Formulate a specific research question about it.
- Explain what we would learn from the answer.

Two examples

Descriptive: private information in insurance markets

Finkelstein and McGarry (2006), American Economic Review (Finkelstein is an MIT professor)

Causal: local effects of large, mixed-income housing

Odayappan (2026), Journal of Housing Economics (Harvard undergraduate senior thesis)

Insurance: research question

Do insurance buyers have private information relevant to their risk?

- Adverse selection as a source of market failure: the “market for lemons”

Insurance: setting

- Supplemental insurance for long-term care expenses in the U.S.
- Insurers assess risk when offering coverage and setting premiums
- Individuals choose whether to buy coverage
- Positive correlation test between insurance choice and risk realization

Insurance: data

Health and Retirement Study: a public survey of aging, health, and finances

- Long-term care insurance ownership and subsequent nursing-home use
- Respondents' own beliefs about their future likelihood of needing care

Insurance: findings

- No evidence that insured people are more likely to enter a nursing home
- Risk expectations predict both insurance ownership and care use, beyond insurers' information

Housing: research question

How do large mixed-income housing developments affect municipal finances and public services?

- Understanding local opposition to new housing

Housing: setting

- Massachusetts Chapter 40B allows zoning waivers for mixed-income housing
- Projects are built at different times with uncertain completion dates
- Difference-in-differences compares changes around openings across municipalities

Housing: data

Records collected and combined from state and federal agencies

- Treatment: Chapter 40B project decisions and opening dates
- Outcomes: population, public safety, schools, and municipal finances
- Sample: municipal panel covering years before and after project openings

Housing: findings

- No detectable deterioration in municipal fiscal health or measured public services
- Population and short-run tax revenue increase

Interpreting results

- A null result can challenge a nonzero prediction from theory or policy claims ([Abadie 2020](#))
- A precise result can reduce uncertainty even when it confirms a prior, including zero

For Monday, September 14

Bring at least five of each:

- Potential research questions
- Potential settings
- Potential data sources